

Interview Summary

The interview focused on **Silver Trust**, a consultancy company with around **30 consultants** and **15 to 20 active projects**. The company delivers business and strategy consulting to other businesses and is planning further growth.

Company setup

Key stakeholders in the discussion were:

- **Robert Singh**: VP of Talent and Operationsx
- **Michelle Zhang**: Senior Project Manager
- **Keisha Williams**: Senior Consultant
- **David Park**: Junior Consultant

The consulting team interviewing them tried to understand the company's current workflow, pain points, and where AI could help.

Current workflow

Silver Trust currently manages project staffing and delivery through a mix of:

- **JIRA** for project tracking
- **spreadsheets** for resource planning and consultant allocation
- **emails**
- **calendars**
- internal meetings and personal knowledge

A typical flow looks like this:

1. A project is approved and tracked in JIRA
2. Robert and Michelle discuss staffing needs
3. Michelle checks consultant calendars and spreadsheet data
4. Consultants are allocated manually
5. JIRA and spreadsheets may be updated
6. The project begins
7. If the skill fit is wrong, the team restarts part of the process

Main challenges identified

1. Resource allocation is highly manual

The biggest issue is not client acquisition, but **deciding whether the company has the capacity to take on new work and which consultants should be assigned.**

This process currently depends on:

- checking multiple tools
- chasing emails
- reviewing calendars
- digging through spreadsheets
- relying on Michelle's and Robert's personal knowledge

Robert said that answering a capacity question can take **2 to 3 days**, and decisions are often based partly on **gut feeling instead of reliable data.**

2. Knowledge is concentrated in one person

Michelle is a major operational hub. She manages the “black book” spreadsheet and holds a lot of unwritten knowledge, such as:

- who has which skills
- who is overloaded
- who works well together
- who should not be assigned together
- who is truly available, beyond what the calendar says

This creates a strong **single-point-of-failure risk**. If Michelle is absent, the process becomes slower and much harder.

3. Tools are fragmented

The company uses JIRA, spreadsheets, calendars, and email, but they do not work together smoothly. JIRA is present, but not fully adopted or used consistently across teams.

The spreadsheet is still essential, especially for planning, but it is disconnected from other systems.

4. Team overload and weak mentoring capacity

Senior consultants are stretched thin. Keisha mentioned she has not taken a vacation in **three years** and has little time to mentor David properly.

This means:

- senior people are overloaded
- junior consultants are not developing in a structured way
- juniors are sometimes placed into difficult projects without enough preparation

5. Staffing decisions are difficult to scale

The company wants to grow, but the current process is heavily dependent on manual coordination and internal memory. That will become harder as the number of consultants and projects increases.

Secondary issues raised

Client-side complexity

The team also mentioned external challenges such as:

- clients changing requirements frequently
- disagreements on budgets and timelines
- cultural mismatch in communication style
- some clients perceiving the company's communication as too direct

These were discussed, but the interview gradually clarified that the **core operational bottleneck is internal staffing and resource planning**, not sales or billing.

Data privacy and compliance

Michelle and the team noted that sharing consultant performance data is sensitive. They mentioned:

- **GDPR compliance**
- upcoming **EU AI regulations**
- the need for approval from legal and HR before sharing certain data

This suggests any AI solution would need to be designed carefully around privacy and compliance.

What the client seems to need

The strongest need that emerged is an **AI-supported resource planning and staffing system** that helps the company:

- assess capacity faster
- allocate consultants more accurately
- reduce dependence on one person's memory
- centralize project and staffing knowledge
- support scaling
- balance workloads better
- preserve flexibility when last-minute changes happen

The solution would likely need to combine structured data from JIRA, calendars, and spreadsheets with softer internal knowledge such as:

- team compatibility
- consultant skill gaps
- workload pressure
- project history

Overall conclusion

The interview revealed that Silver Trust's biggest pain point is **manual, knowledge-heavy resource allocation across multiple projects**. The company is functioning and delivering projects successfully, but the system is fragile, time-consuming, and difficult to scale.

The clearest opportunity for AI is to improve:

- **capacity planning**
- **resource allocation**
- **knowledge capture**
- **workload balancing**
- **training and continuity**

A well-designed solution could reduce operational overhead, improve staffing decisions, free up senior staff for higher-value work, and make the organization more resilient as it grows.